

John 1:1 - Koine Greek

Ἐν ἀρχῇ ἦν ὁ λόγος
καὶ ὁ λόγος ἦν πρὸς τὸν θεόν
καὶ θεὸς ἦν ὁ λόγος

John 1:1 — Koine Greek with Layered English Alignment

Interlinear Alignment Header (Greek → Structural Mapping)

Greek	Transliteration	Structural Gloss Anchor
Ἐν ἀρχῇ	En archē	In [the] beginning
ἦν	ēn	was
ὁ λόγος	ho logos	the Word
καὶ	kai	And
ὁ λόγος	ho logos	the Word
ἦν	ēn	was
πρὸς	pros	toward
τὸν θεόν	ton theon	the God
καὶ	kai	And
θεός	theos	God → divine
ἦν	ēn	was
ὁ λόγος	ho logos	the Word

Structural Bridge Statement

The following English layers preserve increasing levels of interpretive distance from the above Greek text:

- Structural Gloss → syntactic correspondence
- Structural-Semantic Gloss → minimal semantic interpretation
- Paraphrase → semantic rendering with aspectual interpretation
- Morphologically Transparent Paraphrase → grammatical visibility
- Expanded Paraphrase → controlled interpretive inference
- Snapshot Paraphrase → discourse-level aspect interpretation
- Expository Paraphrase → explanatory synthesis

John 1:1 - English Translations

The linguistic observations in this model are compatible with multiple theological frameworks.

Methodological Note

The Structural Gloss intentionally refrains from adopting a specific interpretation of the anarthrous predicate θεός.

The Structural-Semantic Gloss is the first layer at which a qualitative reading of θεός ("divine") is introduced.

Accordingly, the translation layers progress from:

- grammatical form,
- to semantic interpretation,
- to explanatory synthesis.

The qualitative reading of θεός, the snapshot reading of ἦν, and the relational reading of πρὸς are all grammatical and contextual options, but they do not, by themselves, determine a single dogmatic system.

The Expanded and Expository layers reflect one particular interpretive trajectory.

Structural Gloss (English Interlinear)

In [the] beginning was the Word,
And the Word was toward the God,
And God was the Word.

Structural-Semantic Gloss (Alternate, Qualitative θεος Rendering)

In [the] beginning was the Word,
And the Word was toward the God,
And divine was the Word.

Paraphrase (Interpreting Aspect/Quality)

In [the] beginning the Word [already] was,
And the Word [already] was toward God,
And divine [in nature] was the Word.

Morphologically Transparent Paraphrase (Making the Definite Article Visible)

In [the] beginning the Word [already] was,
And the Word [already] was toward [the] God,
And divine [in nature] was the Word.

Expanded Paraphrase with Interpretive Inference

In [the] beginning the Word [already] was,
And the Word [already] was oriented toward God[, in distinction from Him,]
And divine [in nature] was the Word.

Snapshot (Aspectual) Paraphrase

This is the state of things at [the] beginning:

- The Word existed.
- The Word existed in relationship to God.
- The Word was divine in nature.

Expository Paraphrase with Interpretive Inference

This is the state of things at [the] beginning[, that is, at the commencement of creation]:

- The Word existed.
- The Word existed in relationship to God [and yet was distinct from God].
- The Word was divine in nature.

Summary of Linguistic Reasoning Framework (John 1:1)

This section summarizes the interpretive principles underlying three key decisions in this model:

1. the **Snapshot (Imperfect / ἦν) reading**
2. the **qualitative sense of θεός (“divine in nature”)**
3. the semantic range of **πρὸς (pros)**
4. and identifies which translation layers are affected by each decision

Classification of Claims Markers:

- G = grammatically required
- P = grammatically permitted
- C = contextually supported
- T = theologically inferred

1. Snapshot Reading of the Imperfect (ἦν)

Linguistic Basis

The verb ἦν (“was”) appears three times in John 1:1:

- ἦν ὁ λόγος
- ὁ λόγος ἦν πρὸς τὸν θεόν
- θεὸς ἦν ὁ λόγος

Rather than describing sequential events, the repeated imperfect forms can be read as describing **continuous existence viewed as a whole state**. (P)

Reasoning

- The imperfect tense in Greek commonly expresses **ongoing or continuous existence in past reference time**. (P)
- The repetition of ἦν across all three clauses creates a unified depiction of reality rather than narrative progression. (P/C)
- This *naturally* supports a “**snapshot**” **reading**, in which the text presents a fixed state of affairs at “the beginning,” rather than narrating a sequence of events. This reasoning also pulls support from the **discourse use** of the imperfect here, not from tense-form alone. (P/C)

Resulting Interpretive Principle

John 1:1 can be read as a description of an existing state rather than a sequence of actions, a reading that is highly compatible with the repeated imperfect ἦν. (P)

Affected Sections

This reasoning primarily informs:

✓ Snapshot (Aspectual) Paraphrase

- Directly dependent on this interpretation
- Translates clause-level grammar into a unified “state of affairs”

✓ Expository Paraphrase with Interpretive Inference

- Uses snapshot framing as its structural foundation
- Extends it into explanatory summary form

⚠ Indirect influence on

- Paraphrase (minor support for “[already] was” interpretation)
- Morphologically Transparent Paraphrase (aspect marking)

2. Qualitative Nature of θεός (Divine Identity)

Linguistic Basis

The clause:

καὶ θεὸς ἦν ὁ λόγος

places **θεός** in predicate position without the article.

Reasoning

- In Koine Greek, **anarthrous predicate nominatives** frequently express **qualitative meaning** rather than strict identity or classification. (P)
- Word order emphasizes the predicate before the subject (“God/divine was the Word”), reinforcing qualitative force. (P)
- This allows θεός to be understood as describing **nature or essence**, not simply category membership. (P)
- The qualitative reading of θεός has been argued by, among others, Harner, Dixon, and Wallace.

Resulting Interpretive Principle

The clause most naturally emphasizes what the Word is in nature, rather than merely what category it belongs to. (P)

This reading is contextually strong but not grammatically exclusive. (P)

Affected Sections

✓ Paraphrase (Interpreting Aspect/Quality)

- “divine in nature” directly reflects this qualitative reading

✓ Morphologically Transparent Paraphrase

- retains same qualitative interpretation while exposing grammar

✓ Expanded Paraphrase with Interpretive Inference

- preserves “divine in nature” while allowing relational inference

✓ Expository Paraphrase with Interpretive Inference

- maintains “divine nature” as a summarized conclusion

✓ Structural-Semantic Gloss

- “divine was the Word” is the first layer that explicitly adopts a qualitative interpretation of θεός

3. Semantic Range of πρὸς τὸν θεόν (pros + accusative)

Linguistic Basis

The phrase:

ὁ λόγος ἦν πρὸς τὸν θεόν

uses **πρὸς + accusative**, a construction with a broad semantic range.

Reasoning

πρὸς can express:

- spatial direction (“toward”) (G)
- relational orientation (“in relation to”) (G)
- personal encounter (“face-to-face / directed toward another” in context-dependent usage) (G)

In John 1:1:

- The construction is paired with personal referents
- It follows an existential clause
- It functions within a pre-creation description

This supports a meaning of:

directional relational orientation. (G)

theological inference based on the broader Christian reading of John, not the grammar alone, adds the inference that this phrasing may imply a distinction. (P)

Resulting Interpretive Principle

πρὸς expresses relational orientation toward God. (G)

When read together with the rest of the verse, this orientation is often understood to imply distinction while maintaining connection—but that inference arises from the clausal relationship, not from the preposition alone.” (P/C)

Affected Sections

✓ Structural Gloss (English Interlinear)

- “toward the God” reflects literal directional rendering

✓ Paraphrase (Interpreting Aspect/Quality)

- “toward God” as semantic simplification

✓ Morphologically Transparent Paraphrase

- “toward [the] God” explicitly preserves article and structure

✓ Expanded Paraphrase with Interpretive Inference

- “oriented toward God[, in distinction from Him,]” expands semantic range into interpretive relation

✓ Snapshot (Aspectual) Paraphrase (indirect influence)

- “relationship to God” reflects relational reading without lexical expansion of πρὸς

✓ Expository Paraphrase with Interpretive Inference

- “relationship to God[, and yet was distinct from God]” represents full interpretive synthesis

Overall Integration Principle

These three linguistic decisions function together:

- ἦν (imperfect) → establishes a *state snapshot* (P/C)
- θεός (qualitative predicate) → expresses *nature/essence* (P/C)
- πρὸς (relational orientation) → supports, but does not require, *directional distinction within relationship* (P/C/T)

Structural Effect on the Translation Model

Interpretation Principle	Primary Layers Affected
Snapshot (Imperfect / State reading)	Snapshot Paraphrase, Expository Paraphrase
Qualitative θεός	Structural-Semantic Gloss and all subsequent layers
Semantic πρὸς	All layers, increasing expansion in higher tiers

Final Insight

The combined effect of these three linguistic features may be read as a description of:

a continuous pre-temporal state of existence, characterized by relational orientation and a qualitative understanding of the Word's nature.

This structure is what allows the translation hierarchy to move from:

- grammatical form → semantic meaning → interpretive synthesis without collapsing the distinctions between them.

Acknowledgement of Alternate Renderings (Non-Exhaustive)

This model adopts a qualitative reading of θεός, a relational reading of πρὸς, and a snapshot reading of ἦν as its working assumptions, while acknowledging other grammatically possible views.

Alternate Grammatical Reasonings

θεός as qualitative-definite blend

Some argue that θεός here is both qualitative and definite, emphasizing nature while still implying identity.

πρὸς as simple relational proximity

A more minimal reading takes *πρὸς* as indicating relationship without drawing strong conclusions about distinction.

Imperfect ἦν as simple past

The imperfect may be read as a past-tense description without strong aspectual emphasis on “snapshot.”

Alternate Renderings

These renderings illustrate how different theological frameworks select different grammatical options; they are not presented as equally probable or equally grounded in the Greek.

John 1:1 (Minimalist Trajectory)

The rendering selects a qualitative reading of *θεός* without metaphysical inference.

The Minimalist trajectory corresponds to the qualitative layers already present in the translation hierarchy.

In the beginning was the Word,
and the Word was with God,
and the Word was divine in nature. (P/C, based on a qualitative reading)

John 1:1 (Nicene Trajectory)

This rendering selects a qualitative-definite reading of *θεός* and interprets *πρὸς* as implying distinction within unity.

In the beginning was the Word,
and the Word was with God,
and the Word was fully God. (T, based on a qualitative-definite reading)

John 1:1 (Arian Trajectory)

This rendering selects an indefinite reading of *θεός* and interprets *πρὸς* as indicating simple relational proximity.

In the beginning was the Word,
and the Word was with the God,
and a god was the Word. (P/T, based on an indefinite reading)

Hierarchical Fidelity Mapping

Strong Grammatical Grounding (Directly Encoded in Greek)

Structural Gloss

In [the] beginning was the Word,
And the Word was toward the God,
And God was the Word.

Why this fits here

- Mirrors Greek word order and syntax as closely as possible.
 - Preserves:
 - ἦν = “was”
 - ὁ λόγος = “the Word”
 - πρὸς τὸν θεόν = “toward the God”
 - θεὸς ἦν ὁ λόγος = predicate-before-subject structure
 - Makes no attempt to resolve the semantic force of the anarthrous predicate θεός.
 - Primarily concerned with formal correspondence.
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Structural-Semantic Gloss

In [the] beginning was the Word,
And the Word was toward the God,
And divine was the Word.

Why this fits here

- Retains Greek word order and structure.
- Preserves:
 - ἦν = “was”
 - ὁ λόγος = “the Word”
 - πρὸς τὸν θεόν = “toward the God”
 - θεὸς ἦν ὁ λόγος = predicate-before-subject structure

- Introduces a semantic interpretation of θεός as qualitative.
 - Represents the smallest interpretive step beyond purely structural correspondence.
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Moderately Supported (Grammatical Range + Standard Semantic Expansion)

Paraphrase (Interpreting Aspect/Quality)

In [the] beginning the Word [already] was,
And the Word [already] was toward God,
And divine [in nature] was the Word.

Morphologically Transparent Paraphrase

In [the] beginning the Word [already] was,
And the Word [already] was toward [the] God,
And divine [in nature] was the Word.

Why these fit here

- “already was” reflects an interpretation of the imperfect ἦν.
 - “divine in nature” expands the qualitative understanding of θεός.
 - “toward God” is a standard semantic rendering of πρὸς.
 - Article marking ([the]) makes Greek morphology visible.
 - Expands meaning while remaining closely tied to the grammatical form.
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Moderately–Weakly Supported (Aspectual and Discourse-Level Interpretation)

Snapshot (Aspectual) Paraphrase

This is the state of things at [the] beginning:

- The Word existed.
- The Word existed in relationship to God.
- The Word was divine in nature.

Why this fits here

- Interprets the cumulative effect of the repeated imperfect verb ἦν.
 - Presents the verse as a description of an existing state rather than a sequence of events.
 - Moves beyond clause-by-clause translation to discourse-level explanation.
 - Remains closely tethered to the grammatical content of the verse.
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Weakly Supported (Contextual / Interpretive Synthesis)

Expanded Paraphrase with Interpretive Inference

In [the] beginning the Word [already] was,
And the Word [already] was oriented toward God[, in distinction from Him,]
And divine [in nature] was the Word.

Why this fits here

- “oriented toward” expands the semantic force of πρὸς.
 - “in distinction from Him” is an inference drawn from the relationship between clauses 2 and 3.
 - Introduces interpretive conclusions not explicitly encoded in the grammar.
 - Represents synthesis rather than direct translation.
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Most Interpretive (Expository Synthesis)

Expository Paraphrase with Interpretive Inference

This is the state of things at [the] beginning[, that is, at the commencement of creation]:

- The Word existed.
- The Word existed in relationship to God[, and yet was distinct from God].
- The Word was divine in nature.

Why this fits here

- Combines grammatical observation with contextual interpretation.
- Explicitly identifies the beginning as the commencement of creation.
- Explicitly states distinction from God as an inferred conclusion.

- Functions primarily as an exposition of perceived meaning rather than a translation.

Summary Mapping

Layer	Type of Fidelity	Strength of Greek Grounding
Structural Gloss	Syntax / word-order	Strongest
Structural-Semantic Gloss	Syntax + minimal semantic interpretation	Strong
Paraphrase	Semantic + aspectual interpretation	Moderate–Strong
Morphologically Transparent Paraphrase	Grammar visibility	Moderate–Strong
Snapshot (Aspectual) Paraphrase	Discourse-level aspect interpretation	Moderate
Expanded Paraphrase	Interpretive synthesis	Weak–Moderate
Expository Paraphrase	Expository synthesis	Weak

Key Insight

The introduction of the Structural-Semantic Gloss separates two distinct questions:

1. What does the Greek structure say?

- Structural Gloss

2. What is the most likely semantic force of that structure?

- Structural-Semantic Gloss

From there, the remaining layers progressively expand:

1. Formal correspondence (Structural Gloss)
2. Minimal semantic interpretation (Structural-Semantic Gloss)

3. Semantic and aspectual expansion (Paraphrase)
4. Morphological visibility (Morphologically Transparent Paraphrase)
5. Aspectual/discourse explanation (Snapshot Paraphrase)
6. Contextual inference (Expanded Paraphrase)
7. Expository synthesis (Expository Paraphrase)

Each successive layer increases explanatory content while remaining rooted, to varying degrees, in the underlying Greek text.